

Goals

When I bring up playing MMOs to most folks the immediate response is usually: “I don’t really want to grind that much”. There’s nothing wrong with that reasoning but it did make me think about the concept of satisfying MMO grinds and then by extension the concept of satisfying goals. During the writing of the previous blog I’ve basically fleshed out my thoughts and decided it was interesting enough to warrant its own thing

Why People Have Goals

I personally think there are 2 types of motivators that contribute to any goal: Extrinsic and Intrinsic. Extrinsic forces in the context of games are objectives the developers set like clearing a boss or solving a puzzle. Intrinsic forces are personal reasons for setting a particular goal. This is a lot more flexible and can be from perceived social clout, desire for lucrative rewards, or simply for the sake of doing it.



*Watching Lathland follow the activity guide like a good honest player
(btw shameless plug since I think this video is an AMAZING introduction to OSRS so if you have 4 hours...)
((There's also dark psychology at play here iykyk))*

Some people might have too many intrinsic motivators...



There are no laws against this Batman...

For a more relatable example let's have two students Machiavelli and Pyrr. Both students have an upcoming test in a subject important to their chosen industry so as an extrinsic motivator both want to pass to further their career. Machiavelli doesn't really care about actually learning and only wants the high grade for a better resume. As a result they brute-force memorize all the patterns seen in the practice material. Pyrr on the other hand enjoys the subject since they think the problems themselves are fascinating. As a result Pyrr spends a lot more time understanding the underlying theory behind the solutions and even digs a little bit into how the various topics appear in the industry. From this we can classify both our goals for each individual but also their path towards their new baseline:

- Machiavelli only cares about the results since they've been told it's needed for their industry. Since there's no personal interest they only have extrinsic factors (eg. they want to make lots of money in this industry). Because of this they're willing to have a shaky foundation right now if it means they can get the same result in less time. In their mind they can learn the material later if necessary.
- Pyrr still cares about the results since they want to pass the class but to them, a good score on the test reflects a deeper understanding of the material they find interesting. With this additional personal interest in the material Pyrr will have a good foundation regardless of the end result but in the process Pyrr will take up a lot more time reviewing and reflecting on their problem sets

With this black-and-white example it's obvious to see what's extrinsic vs intrinsic as well as which path prepares the student better in the future BUT what I find interesting is that some people actually internalize extrinsic motivators. So it's soapbox time!

W Soapbox: External Thoughts

While I was doing an internship in San Francisco a friend asked if I've had a quarter-life crisis yet. At the time I was like 20 so I basically made the friend explain to me the concept and from what I've gathered it's basically newly graduated folks realizing that the 9-5 life is not the end of their goals but rather another beginning. Of course there are other definitions and for something so personal people might internalize and experience it differently however as a trend I do think quarter-life crises do exist.

Specifically I think there's a type of thought process that perpetuates quarter-life crises and it's one where you're told to complete a checklist in order to "make it" in life. Since many folks hear that at a young age these teachings go from one of the factors for why they pursue a goal into the only reason why they pursue a goal. As an outside viewer it's easy to demean this type of thinking but when the individual has always seemed to achieve their goals with that mindset it's hard to blame them for sticking with that thought process. After all, if they just get into that university or company or relationship then everything will be sunshine and rainbows... Right?

For some folks maybe it IS all fun and games but I suspect many find the juxtaposition of what they *believe* and what they *experience* to vary enough to make them question everything leading up to that point. In addition most folks end up living away from their parental figures so the original goal setters are much less involved with the day-to-day. There's nothing inherently wrong with this (and many actually find this quite liberating) but for folks who've always been given a checklist of things to do to be "happy" there's definitely a void that isn't immediately replaced UNLESS...

You end up assimilating your role at work as your new identity. Since this blog isn't about WLB I'll just leave my only comment as: This is not sustainable.

Oh I suppose some other folks fill that void with the classic quarter-life crisis hobbies like running, rock climbing, raving, etc. I actually do have thoughts on the common quarter-life crisis trends but once again that isn't the focus so... my only comment is that it's performative!

I will admit that over time folks who stick with those hobbies are no longer larping but I find the concept of forcing yourself into a hobby to either socialize with folks or to make new goals truly insane. My sentiment mostly stems from the question of: Are your current hobbies so "complete" and "isolated" that you truly cannot find a new way to challenge yourself or socialize with others? Maybe I'm the odd one out but even

content I watch like Hololive streams or Scott the Woz tangents can inspire me to write up new goals and think about topics previously abandoned. Even grindy games like Maplestory (which I still think don't respect your time) have given me a lot of different avenues to both fronts so in my mind I always assume people who jump to more common hobbies just assume the hobby itself will set the goals and provide a community who will instantly welcome them.

As a quick breather before I get into the final section, if you've made it this far congrats! I normally don't write blogs like these because I don't think I'm in a place to give advice and I also don't think this is the best medium. However this blog is a cathartic way for me to sunset a lot of the "goal-setting" comments and sections I write because I want to keep the joy of writing blogs and everything else separate. Of course this doesn't mean I WON'T talk about hobbies or other fun things I do IRL but it's more along the lines of leaving out specific goals like:

- Kalphite Queen mounted head for Elite Desert Diary in OSRS
- Underhand rowing 3 plates for reps at the gym on pull day
- Attempting Hard Seren clears pre-genesis liberation

After all, most folks can barely relate to my gym blogs and then after that are the rabbit holes of Maplestory and OSRS. Another benefit is that I get to make the blogs shorter which helps the dedicated readers (thanks btw) not have to skim through all the nitty-gritty details of a game that they personally aren't as invested in.

This disconnect between what I'm interested in and what people want to read is a major reason why I'm going to likely revisit how I do blogs. At this point I've proven to myself that if I *WANTED* to do a 9-day blog cadence I can do it for 11 months but *SHOULD* I keep this cadence is another question. Not only does it feel shockingly parasocial but I'm starting to suspect that no matter how many blogs I put out, people's perceptions of me will always stick with whatever they find most bizarre so whatever!

Dunno when the next blog will be but quite likely not in 9 days.

- ratratrat33